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Life-crisis rituals among the Kenuz

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Engagement marked a decided change in the behavior of a girl, who was expected to attract no attention after the news became public. She remained in her courtyard, except for trips to the Nile for water, and did not attend public events. This behavior, which male migrants often misinterpreted as the proper conduct for all unmarried adolescent girls, could be viewed as protective semiseclusion. Probably it had this aspect, since her new status opened an engaged girl to danger from the evil eye. But the person from whom she was most strongly urged to conceal herself was her fiancé.

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Contact between an engaged couple was explicitly forbidden, even when they were close relatives or neighbors who had formerly seen each other daily. Whatever the rationale underlying this prohibition, most men treated the custom as a joke and plotted to evade the rule. This often turned into a game, with some girls trying to help him while others warned his fiancée. Learning which path she took to the Nile, he would lie in wait to confront her. His attempts were never entirely successful. An engaged girl always walked with a party of women, and never alone. If warned of his ploy, she either took a different route or else arranged her scarf to conceal her face. If they did meet unexpectedly, she covered her face and hurried away. Those few men who had married according to a parent's orders without having seen their fiancées first sometimes objected to this situation. Thus Q, who came back to Dahmit to marry a girl his mother had chosen for him, complained that the only glimpse he caught of her was one afternoon when his mother, from a distance, drew his attention to several girls coming from the river and said that his fiancée was the fourth one. And even after his marriage, he resented this, noting that he was not certain he had counted correctly and might have been looking at the wrong girl. This attitude provides a further illustration of the importance

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that men placed on seeing a girl before they married her. Other migrants in Q's situation might have demanded the right to visit Dahmit and see the girl in person before consenting to the marriage.

SHELAH

The shelah proper was the groom's providing the bride's family with food and other supplies, which were intended for their use for the wedding-feast held at the home on the leylet-el-henna, and were also supposed to cover the period after the wedding, conventionally lasting 40 days, during which he did not openly contribute to household expenses. Its contents included flour and grain, rice, tea, sugar, kerosene, perfume, sharbat, and candy. The amounts depended on the length he planned his period of matrilocal residence to last. A shelah also included one or more sheep or goats to be sacrificed for the feast, although a groom also had the options of giving money with which they could purchase these, or sending them meat from animals his family sacrificed on the wedding day. Like the waddah, the term shelah also denoted the celebration that attended its presentation.

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In its basic outlines, the shelah celebration conformed to the basic pattern of the waddah and the wedding itself, beginning with festivities at the groom's house and moving in a procession to the house of the bride, where the main celebration occurred. Intermediate in time, it usually fell a week after the waddah and a week before the wedding. It was also intermediate in scale—much more elaborate than the waddah and actively involving both sexes. Only a few men attended a waddah celebration, where they were clearly peripheral. A large group of men joined a shelah presentation, usually coming in response to formal invitations.

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On the shelah morning, each woman guest coming to the groom's house brought his mother a small quantity of food—flour, sugar, dates, etc.—which could be added to the shelah itself or kept to use in preparing the wedding-feast. If not compensation for similar donations from her in the past, such gifts were repaid in the same form at future events. The guests were sexually segregated, women gathering in the courtyard of the house and men sitting in the mandara or, if the house lacked this structure, using one which a neighbor had offered. Men attending a shelah simply talked. Women actively celebrated with singing and dancing. The groom's family served sharbat and tea, besides dates and asleyk.

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